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Flexibility of the Home and Psychological Wellbeing

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Abstract

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Abstract

Flexibility in the design of our homes can greatly support our varied and changing needs and functions but its ability to support our psychological wellbeing at home has not been empirically examined or established. In exploring the same in this thesis, Flexibility was conceptualised as the architectural design of the home (Architectural Flexibility) but also residents' behaviour of making changes to the home (Behavioural Flexibility) which was found to be lacking in the literature. Residents' hedonic and eudaimonic wellbeing were measured using two newly developed and validated scales. In an online mixed-method survey, Study 1 (N = 187) established a positive association between Flexibility of the home and residents' Hedonic and Eudaimonic wellbeing. Qualitative data analyses provided insights into features of the home and modifications made to home, which were used to measure Flexibility more objectively in studies 2 and 3. In an online survey (N = 212), Study 2 found that Behavioural Flexibility substantially mediated the relationship between Architectural Flexibility of the home and residents' Hedonic and Eudaimonic wellbeing. In an online survey, Study 3 further confirmed the mediating effect of behaviour of making modifications to home on the relationship between Architectural Flexibility and Eudaimonic wellbeing using a nationally representative sample (N = 300). The study also found that the residents' personal factors of capabilities and motivations substantially contribute to the model. An additional experimental part of Study 3 suggested that there may exist a causal relationship between Architectural Flexibility of the home and residents' wellbeing. Overall,

findings from this thesis suggest that Architectural and Behavioural Flexibility of the home have varied but positive influence on residents’ Hedonic and Eudaimonic wellbeing at home. This relationship is substantially influenced by residents’ capabilities and motivations, and may need to be considered when designing homes or developing housing policies in the UK.

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